

Atayalic subjects and the nature of nominative

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Abstract This paper investigates the nature of subjecthood properties in the Atayalic group of Austronesian languages of Taiwan. Subjects in these languages are associated with a clause-final, high structural position and exhibit topic properties, while also being morphologically reduced as compared to non-nominative case-marked nominals. I therefore propose a model of Austronesian voice alternations, in the *wh/case*-agreement tradition, where subject promotion involves structure-removal of an argument's K layer. What is traditionally described as nominative-marking, then, reflects the D layer of a K-less nominal, which then must be in the higher clausal phase. The analysis is motivated further from the limited availability of nominative-marked non-subject nominals, attested in Squliq Atayal and Seediq.

Keywords Subjecthood, nominative case, structure removal, Philippine-type voice systems, Squliq Atayal, Seediq

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1 Introduction

What properties make a subject a subject? In many languages, a subject stands apart from other nominals in a clause by virtue of its distinct morphological coding (e.g. *nominative case*) and designated structural position. Morphology on the verb (e.g. *voice morphology*) may also serve to identify the thematic role of the subject.

All three of these properties hold of the subject in the Atayalic group of Austronesian languages of Taiwan. Consider the Squliq Atayal examples in (1) below, which illustrate an alternation between the so-called Actor Voice (AV) and Patient Voice (PV) with a bivalent verb ‘eat.’¹ In both examples, the subject is the argument in clause-final position and the one that can bear the optional marker *qu*’, which has traditionally been described as a nominative (or absolutive) case maker. The non-subject arguments may be preceded by other case-marking articles, but not *qu*’. The choice of subject also correlates with the choice of voice morphology on the verb, in a manner I discuss in greater detail below.

(1) Voice and subjecthood in Squliq Atayal:

- a. Cyux m-anìq (squ’) sehuy (**qu**’) Yuraw.

AUX AV-eat OBL.D taro NOM Yuraw

‘Yuraw is eating (the) taro.’

- b. Cyux niq-un (na’) Yuraw (**qu**’) sehuy qasa.

AUX eat-PV GEN Yuraw NOM taro DIST

‘Yuraw is eating that taro.’

Atayalic subjects are additionally associated with two other properties, which will be illustrated below: they exhibit discourse topic status and are the only nominal argument which can undergo A’-movement. These are both widely attested properties of subjects across western Austronesian languages (see e.g. Chen & McDonnell 2019). In most cases, all of these various subjecthood properties uniquely and unambiguously identify the subject in Atayalic clauses.

In this paper, I investigate the nature of subjects in Atayalic, with particular emphasis on the nature of nominative case and its derivation. First, I argue that nominatives are structurally smaller than other case-marked nominals. Nominative nominals are DPs, whereas non-nominative nominals are KPs, where K is above D on the functional hierarchy, as has been previously hypothesized on independent grounds by Bittner & Hale (1996).² I propose a derivational view of this alternation, wherein the process of a

¹ In addition to Leipzig glosses, I use the following abbreviations here: PN = proper name; AV = Actor Voice, PV = Patient Voice, LV = Locative Voice, CV = Conveyance Voice, NAV = Non-Actor Voice (see section 2.1). See also section 2.2 for D, as in OBL.D (1a) and GEN.D. I gloss all temporal auxiliaries as AUX here, as their exact semantics are not crucial here.

² See also Kornfilt & Preminger 2015, McFadden 2018, Smith et al. 2019, Zompì 2019. The idea that nominative case is associated with a reduced structure as compared to other morphological cases has also been claimed to be typologically true;

nominal becoming the subject therefore involves *removal* of its K head. Second, I propose that there are distinct requirements on nominal extended projections in the higher and lower domains of the clause: nominals in the CP phase must be DPs, whereas nominals in the clause-medial, verbal phase must be KPs. Subjects, by virtue of being DPs, must then move out of the lower phase, then generally occupying a topic position in the CP domain. Subsequent TP fronting yields the observed clause-final subject position (following Aldridge 1999 et seq, Holmer 2005, a.o.).

Evidence for my proposal comes from the fact that, under very limited circumstances, a non-subject can bear nominative marking. Consider the examples in (2) below, which are both AV clauses but where the theme, rather than the agent, bears nominative case. This is possible only when the subject undergoes A'-movement (2a) or is a second-position clitic pronoun (2b). In just these cases, the clause-final topic position remains empty and so a non-subject nominal may occupy it; however, as the nominal then is part of the CP phase, it must appear as a DP rather than a KP, and hence descriptively appears in nominative case.

(2) **Nominative non-subject constructions:**

- a. Ima qu' wal m-anig **qu'** sehuy qasa? [Squliq]
 who NOM AUX AV-eat NOM taro DIST
 'Who ate that taro?'
- b. Q<m><n>ita =ku **ka** boyak. [Seediq; Holmer 1996: 67]
 <AV><PFV>see =NOM.1SG NOM boar
 'I saw the boar.'

This work — and especially the discussion of the detailed behavior of the nominative non-subject constructions in Squliq Atayal as in (2a) — is based on my original fieldwork in 2012 with five speakers of Squliq Atayal who grew up in Fuhshing township, Taoyuan county, Taiwan. All uncredited data come from this fieldwork. In particular, except where noted otherwise, the key behaviors in Squliq that I introduce in section 4 as evidence for my proposal reflect the consistent judgments of my three primary speakers, across multiple sessions, tested with multiple lexicalizations. Unfortunately, due to the time elapsed since this earlier fieldwork, the data available to me now is limited to these earlier field notes. For this reason, I also draw heavily upon data reported in existing literature on Squliq Atayal, as well as prior descriptions of other Atayalic languages which reinforce my claims.³ I will explicitly note relevant points of attested variation and gaps in the available data.

see especially Blake 2001, Caha 2009, 2024, and citations there.

³ Sources vary slightly in their orthographic conventions. Therefore, in most cases, I simply reproduce the orthographic forms in the original sources, but align glosses and the form of translations to facilitate comparison.

This paper is structured as follows. I first introduce the basic syntactic organization of the clause in Atayalic languages in section 2, highlighting salient differences between individual language varieties and relevant properties of the morphology of the prenominal markers. I then introduce my proposal in section 3, and then discuss the possibility and behavior of nominative-marked non-subjects in section 4, which provides further motivation for the account. I conclude in section 5 with an outlook on the broader application and predictions of my novel proposal here for Philippine-type voice alternations.

2 Basics of Atayalic syntax

The term Atayalic refers to a proposed subgroup of Austronesian languages spoken across the mountainous regions of northern Taiwan, with two member languages, Atayal and Seediq (Li 1981). Traditionally, varieties of Atayal have been broadly classified into two dialect groups, Squliq and C’uli’ (Li 1985, L. Huang 1995b; but see also Goderich 2020). I will therefore generally label examples with this three-way classification (Seediq, Squliq, or C’uli’), making note of more specific dialect and community information in passing where relevant. All uncredited data on Squliq Atayal comes from my earlier fieldwork, as noted above.

Despite many lexical and phonological differences (see especially Goderich 2020) and various minor morphosyntactic differences (see e.g. L. Huang 1995b), the members of the Atayalic group are alike in the overall syntactic organization of the clause. I first introduce these core, shared properties, highlighting the properties of subjects, in section 2.1, illustrating many points primarily with examples from Squliq Atayal. I then discuss the inventory of case markers in greater detail in section 2.2 and present additional properties associated with subjects in section 2.3.

2.1 Voice, case, and word order

The Atayalic languages are typologically classified as so-called “Philippine-type” Austronesian languages. These languages are characterized by their so-called “voice systems” including two or more Non-Actor Voices (Blust 2010: 307), as well as predicate-initial word order, prenominal case-marking articles, and second-position clitic pronouns (Wolff 1996, Himmelmann 2002, 2005, Ross 2002, Blust 2010, 2013, Chen & McDonnell 2019).

Atayalic languages have four voices, illustrated in (3) below with the stem ‘eat’ *qaniq* in Squliq Atayal. Each voice form corresponds to a different choice of event participant being the clause’s subject, which is definite, preceded by the nominative marker *qu’*, and generally in clause-final position as in (3) below. With a notionally bivalent verb such as ‘eat,’ Actor Voice (AV) and Patient Voice (PV) forms naturally take the verb’s agent and theme arguments as subjects, respectively (3a,b). Voices can also

identify a non-obligatory participant of the event description as the subject, as seen in the Locative Voice (LV) and Circumstantial Voice (CV) examples in (3c,d) below. Some earlier works refer to the fourth form as Instrumental/Benefactive Voice, corresponding to two of the CV form's prominent uses, which are both illustrated in (3d) below.

(3) **Four-way voice alternation:**

[Squliq; A. Liu 2004: 27]

- a. **M**-aniq quliq qu' Tali'.
 AV-eat fish NOM Tali
 'Tali eats fish.' Actor Voice (AV)
- b. Niq-**un** na' Tali' qu' qulih qasa.
 eat-PV GEN Tali NOM fish DIST
 'Tali eats that fish.' Patient Voice (PV)
- c. Niq-**an** na' Tali qulih qu' ngasal qasa.
 eat-LV GEN Tali fish NOM house DIST
 'Tali eats fish in that house.' Locative Voice (LV)
- d. S-qaniq na' Tali qulih qu' {qway / Sayun}.
 CV-eat GEN Tali fish NOM chopsticks Sayun
 'Tali eats fish {with chopsticks / for Sayun}.' Circumstantial Voice (CV)

Noun phrases can be introduced by prenominal markers, which I refer to pretheoretically as *articles*, or be bare. The marking of non-subject noun phrases varies by the thematic roles being expressed. For instance, it is generally the case that non-subject agents are genitive-marked (which is also the form of nominal possessors; see *na' Tali'* in (3b–d)) whereas, in Squliq, non-subject themes are often unmarked (simply *qulih* in (3a,c–d)) but otherwise oblique-marked (see example (1a) above and note 7). For noun phrases that express conceptually optional information about the described situation, the examples in (4–5) below illustrate a couple alternations between LV and CV subjects and their corresponding non-subject forms.⁴

⁴ These patterns of argument coding — including the case-marking on non-subject participants with different thematic roles, as well as which voice form is used when a particular type of participant is the subject — can vary based on the individual verb's lexical conceptual structure and the clause's aspectual specification, and also vary across individual Atayalic varieties. For detailed illustrations and discussions of these patterns, I refer readers to works such as L. Huang 2001 on Matu'uwal (a C'uli' variety referred to in many earlier works by its exonym *Mayrinax*), S. Chen 2007 and Yeh 2013 on Squliq, Tsukida 2009: 355ff and Tang 2010 on Truku Seediq, among others.

(4) **Location as oblique adjunct versus LV subject:**

[Squliq; S. Chen 2007: 9, 61]

- | | |
|---|---|
| a. Cyux m-'abi sa kulu qu hozil qasa.
AUX AV-sleep OBL basin NOM dog DIST
'That dog is sleeping in a basin.' | b. 'abi-an na' yaya qu' sakau=su'.
sleep-LV GEN mother NOM bed=GEN.2SG
'Mother is sleeping in your bed.' |
|---|---|

(5) **Instrument as genitive adjunct versus CV subject:**

[Squliq; S. Chen 2007: 27]

- | | |
|--|---|
| a. Bhiy-un =maku na hoku qu Tali.
hit-PV =GEN.1sg GEN stick NOM Tali
'I hit Tali with a stick.' | b. S-bihi =maku Tali qu hoku qani.
CV-hit =GEN.1sg Tali NOM stick PROX
'I hit Tali with this stick.' |
|--|---|

Like other so-called Philippine-type languages, the Atayalic languages also have pronouns that are second-position clitics. Clitic pronouns follow the first preverbal auxiliary or negator, if present, and otherwise follow the verb. See (6a,b) below. Clitic pronouns are only available for subjects and non-subject agents (glossed nominative and genitive, respectively), as is the case across all Philippine-type languages (Erlewine & Levin 2021). The two can cooccur, as in (6c).

(6) **Second-position clitic pronouns:**

[Squliq]

- | | |
|---|--|
| a. Nyux = maku niq-un qu' yutak qani.
AUX =GEN.1sg eat-PV NOM taro PROX
'I am eating this taro.' | b. Niq-un = maku qu' qulih qani.
eat-PV =GEN.1sg NOM fish PROX
'I eat this fish.' |
| c. Nyux = saku = nha kt-an.
AUX =NOM.1sg =GEN.3pl see-LV
'They see me.' | |

An important generalization that holds across the Atayalic languages is that — except in the limited circumstances that I discuss in section 4 below — only the subject can bear nominative case. I illustrate this explicitly for Squliq Atayal in (7) below. Note too that the subject's nominative article can be dropped in Squliq, but nominative case is still not possible on non-subjects even if the immediately pre-subject *qu'* is omitted.

(7) **Non-subject arguments (generally) cannot bear nominative case:**

[Squliq]

- a. Cyux m-aniq {squ' / *qu'} sehuy qasa (qu') Yuraw.

AUX AV-eat OBL.D NOM taro DIST NOM Yuraw

‘Yuraw is eating that taro.’

- b. Cyux niq-un {na' / *qu'} Yuraw (qu') sehuy qasa.

AUX eat-PV GEN NOM Yuraw NOM taro DIST

‘Yuraw is eating that taro.’

Another property of Atayalic subjects is their clause-final position. Specifically, when the subject is expressed as a full noun phrase (rather than a clitic pronoun) following the verb, it generally appears at the end of the clause, followed only by certain final particles (discussed in section 3.3) and embedded clauses (analyzed as right-extraposed; see e.g. C.-K. Shih 2012). For example, full noun phrase subjects are described as obligatorily clause-final in Seediq (see e.g. Holmer 1996: 57–58, Aldridge 2004: 33ff) and Squliq Atayal (see e.g. Huang & Hayung 2018: 41ff, A. Liu 2017: 35–37). The examples in (8) illustrate this requirement for the agent and theme of ‘eat’ in Squliq Atayal, in both AV and PV.

(8) **Clause-final subject requirement:**

[Squliq; A. Liu 2017: 36–37]

- a. M-aniq {qulih} qu' Watan {*qulih}.

AV-eat fish NOM Watan

‘Watan eats fish.’

- b. Niq-an {na' Watan} qu' qulih qasa {*na' Watan}.

eat-LV GEN Watan NOM fish DIST

‘Watan eats that fish.’

Synthesizing such reports, I will take subjects across Atayalic varieties to indeed be associated with a clause-final position in the general case.⁵ This description will inform my structural analysis in section 3 below.

2.2 Prenominal articles

Next, I turn to the inventory of prenominal articles and their use, starting first with Atayal and addressing Seediq below.

As we have already seen in examples above, prenominal articles in Atayal reflect at least a three-way distinction in morphological case, which I gloss as nominative, genitive, and oblique.⁶ These three

⁵ I am aware of just one exception to the clause-final position of subjects in Atayalic, in Matu'uwal C'uli, which I address in note 17 below.

categories of articles share the property that they each correspond to an abstract group of noun phrase types, rather than to a specific thematic role. We have already emphasized that nominative is associated with subjects, which can reflect a diverse range of thematic roles (3). In addition, we have already seen above that genitive articles can introduce both agents (3b–d) and instruments (5a), whereas oblique articles can both introduce themes (7a) and locations (4a). There are also other prenominal articles with much more restricted uses, such as the locative marker *te* and comitative *ki*’ in Squliq (see especially Huang & Hayung 2011, and note 9 below), but here I will concentrate on the form and uses of the nominative, genitive, and oblique.

The genitive and oblique articles for common nouns in Atayal each come in two, related forms. In Matu’uwal C’uli’, these are *na*’ / *nku*’ and *cu*’ / *cku*’, respectively. In Matu’uwal, the choice between the two forms in each pair reflects a clear semantic difference, which has been described in terms of “specificity” (Li 1995) or “referentiality” (L. Huang 1995a). Consider the minimal pairs in (9–10) below, with translations reproduced from their sources. Here I gloss *nku*’ and *cku*’, as well as their cognates, as GEN.D and OBL.D, respectively, with D simply being an annotation that foreshadows my analysis below.

(9) **Instruments with genitive *na*’ vs *nku*’ in Matu’uwal:** [C’uli’; Li 1995: 27]

- a. M-aniq **na**’ qaquay cu’ qulih ku’ ’ulaqi’.
 AV-eat GEN chopsticks OBL fish NOM child
 ‘The child ate fish with chopsticks.’
- b. M-aniq **nku**’ qaquay cu’ qulih ku’ ’ulaqi’.
 AV-eat GEN.D chopsticks OBL fish NOM child
 ‘The child ate fish with a certain pair of chopsticks.’

(10) **Themes with oblique *cu*’ vs *cku*’ in Matu’uwal:** [C’uli’; L. Huang 1995a: 94]

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>a. M-aniq cu’ qulih ku’ ’ulaqi’.
 AV-eat OBL fish NOM child
 ‘The child is eating fish.’</p> | <p>b. M-aniq cku’ qulih ku’ ’ulaqi’.
 AV-eat OBL.D fish NOM child
 ‘The child is eating the fish.’</p> |
|--|---|

To my knowledge, Matu’uwal C’uli’ is unique among contemporary Atayal varieties in expressing a clear semantic contrast with each of these pairs of articles. For other Atayal varieties, the choice of

⁶ I adopt this choice of terminology from more historical and typologically oriented work on Austronesian argument-marking, such as Ross 2006, Blust 2015, and De Busser 2024.

Note that there is also another tradition of describing Philippine-type Austronesian languages as ergative, as reflected in Aldridge’s earlier work on Seediq. From this ergative perspective, what I call “nominative” and “genitive” here would be referred to respectively as “absolutive” and “ergative,” with the latter syncretic with the genitive case of possessors. Note, however, that Aldridge (2004: 31ff) herself refers to the Seediq *ka* marker as a “topic marker,” motivated by data that I will discuss in section 4 below.

article within each pair seems to either be somewhat conventionalized, or in apparent free variation. For example, for the Squliq speakers that I have consulted, non-subject themes can be introduced by OBL.D *squ*⁷ (see (1a, 7a)) but never by OBL *sa*, whereas OBL *sa* is preferred over OBL.D *squ*⁷ for locations.

The inventories of nominative, genitive, and oblique articles for common nouns in three Atayal varieties are presented in (11) below. The third row, Pngawan, refers to a variety spoken in Ren'ai township (Nantou county) as described by L. Huang (2006). Some varieties also have separate forms for proper names, but here I will concentrate on the forms of common noun articles.

(11) **Articles for common nouns in three Atayal varieties:**

	NOM	GEN	GEN.D	OBL	OBL.D
Squliq	qu'	na'	nqu'	sa	squ'
Matu'uwal (C'uli')	ku' ⁸	na'	nku'	cu'	cku'
Pngawan (C'uli')	ka'	na'	naka'	ci'	cika'

Now notice that there is a formal similarity between the nominative article and the GEN.D and OBL.D forms in each variety. More specifically, as authors such as Ferrell (1979: 204), Liao (2004: 303), and Ross (2006: 530) have noted, the GEN.D and OBL.D variants appear to reflect combinations of the genitive and oblique articles with the nominative, which is itself associated with definiteness. This is especially clear with the forms in Pngawan, with the Squliq and Matu'uwal forms reflecting minor contractions. This evidence from the morphological paradigms of articles suggests that genitive and oblique noun phrases are structurally larger than, and can properly contain, what have been called nominative noun phrases.

In contrast to all Atayal varieties, Seediq varieties exhibit a significantly reduced inventory of prenominal articles. In Tgdaya/Paran Seediq, there are only two articles, *ka* and *na* (Holmer 1996: 66–67; see also Chang 1997: 12): *ka* may precede subjects, *na* may precede non-subject agents, and non-subject themes are always bare. Truku Seediq only maintains the *ka* nominative article, with genitives being formally unmarked, and has innovated an oblique case suffix (see e.g. Tsukida 2005).

Even with this significantly reduced inventory of articles, evidence from Tgdaya Seediq suggests that the genitive is formally larger than, and can contain, a nominative form. Holmer (1996) observes that a

⁷ As noted above, non-subject themes in Squliq Atayal are frequently bare, without any prenominal article. See for instance the data in (3), reproduced from A. Liu 2017. Huang & Tanangkingsing (2011: 102) and S. Huang (2017: 12) also report Squliq Atayal examples with *squ*-marking on themes of non-PV clauses, parallel to the behavior of my own Squliq speakers.

More generally, individual Atayal dialects vary substantially in the obligatoriness and frequency of use of articles. For example, L. Huang (1995b: 274) reports that the prenominal articles are obligatory in Matu'uwal C'uli' but frequently dropped in conversation in the Wulai dialect of Squliq Atayal.

⁸ Li (1995) and L. Huang (1995a) describe *ku*' as the specific/referential form of the nominative article, which alternates with a non-specific/non-referential form, *a*'. However, examples of its usage (see e.g. Li 1995: 28, L. Huang 1995a: 90–91) show that *a*' introduces predicate nominals and kind descriptions, which are cross-linguistically associated with reduced noun phrases that do not project D (see e.g. Chierchia 1998). It therefore is not syntactically on par with *ku*', which I will analyze below as a D head.

genitive non-subject agent or nominal possessor may appear with a combination of both markers, *na ka*, when the speaker intends to strongly contrast a genitive argument against a contextual alternative. See (12) below.

(12) **Contrastive genitives with *na ka* in Tgdaya:** [Seediq; Holmer 1996: 73, 128]

- a. runge **na ka** Pawan
 monkey GEN NOM Pawan
 ‘Pawan’s monkey (not Awi’s monkey)’
- b. ... laqi [RC napa **na ka** Temu]
 child carry.PV.PFV GEN NOM Temu
 ‘the child that Temu carried (not the one Awi carried)’

This pattern of apparent “case stacking” is reminiscent of case-stacking in Korean and Amis, another Formosan Austronesian language. Multiple case markers can cooccur on a single nominal only if it is focused in Korean (see e.g. Yoon 1996, 2004, Gerdtz & Youn 1999, Schütze 2001) or a contrastive topic in Amis (T. Chen 2018: ch. 4). Both Levin (2017: 481) and T. Chen (2018: 183) therefore propose constraints that restrict multiple case realization to these limited information-structural contexts. These forms directly reflect the syntactic structure that I propose below for the extended noun phrase. I then suggest that the two markers are subject to a similar constraint as that which Levin and T. Chen propose for Korean and Amis.

I conclude that, quite generally across Atayalic, there is a structural asymmetry between nominative case and the other core cases (genitive and oblique): Nominative is structurally smaller, and in fact can appear as a proper subpart of a genitive or oblique noun phrase, but not vice versa. Faithfully reflecting and explaining this morphological pattern will be an important and unique feature of my syntactic proposal, in section 3.

2.3 Other subjecthood properties

So far, we have observed that one argument in each clause — the subject — is distinguished from other phrases in its role being reflected in the choice of voice morphology, bearing nominative case, and generally being in clause-final position. In this section, we introduce two other properties of Atayalic subjects: the subject-only restriction on $\bar{A}$ -extraction and the topic/givenness properties of subjects.

The $\bar{A}$ -extraction restriction In many Philippine-type Austronesian languages, the subject is the only nominal argument that can undergo $\bar{A}$ -movement (see e.g. Aldridge 2004 and Erlewine, Levin & Van Urk 2017, although see also Erlewine & C. Lim 2023 and Hsieh 2020, 2025 for discussion of some

exceptions). In Atayalic languages, gapped relativization, gapped argument topicalization, and ex-situ argument *wh*/focus constructions are all be constrained by this subject-only restriction.

Consider the minimal pairs of Squliq ex-situ *wh*-questions in (13–14) below. For an initial *wh*-phrase to be interpreted as filling a postverbal agent gap, the verb must be in AV in (13). For it to be interpreted as a postverbal theme gap, the verb must be in PV in (14). In other words, only the subject can be gapped in this way. In-situ *wh*-questions are also possible, as I discuss below.

(13) **Ex-situ agent *wh*-question $\Rightarrow$ AV:** [Squliq]

- a. Ima (qu') [p-hapuy sehuy qani ____]?
 who NOM AV.FUT-cook taro PROX
 'Who will cook these taro?'
- b. *Ima (qu') [puy-un ____ (qu') sehuy]?
 who NOM cook-PV NOM taro
 Intended: 'Who will cook these taro?'

(14) **Ex-situ theme *wh*-question $\Rightarrow$ PV:** [Squliq]

- a. Nanu (qu') [wal niq-un (na') Yuraw ____]?
 what NOM AUX eat-PV GEN Yuraw
 'What did Yuraw eat?'
- b. *Nanu (qu') [m-anik ____ (qu') Yuraw]?
 what NOM AV-eat NOM Yuraw
 Intended: 'What did Yuraw eat?'

I follow Aldridge (2002, 2004: 311ff, 2013) on Seediq in the view that such ex-situ argument *wh*-questions (and structurally parallel focus constructions) are biclausal, with the *wh* or focus phrase being the matrix predicate of a null copular clause, with a headless relative (in brackets in (13–14)) as its subject. (See also Paul 2001 and Potsdam 2009.) This description immediately explains the availability of nominative marking (*qu'*) preceding the gapped clause, in brackets above.

Other $\bar{A}$ -movement constructions also exhibit this subject-only extraction restriction, in Squliq as well as in other Atayalic languages. In the interest of space, I refer the reader to prior works which illustrate the subject-only restriction, including with negative data for the ungrammaticality of non-subject extractions. For Squliq Atayal, A. Liu (2004, 2005, 2017) has previously documented the subject-only restriction for head-external relatives (2004: 44, 2005: 99), ex-situ *wh*-constructions (2017: 256), ex-situ focus constructions (2017: 248, 253), and gapped topics (2017: 202–207). For C'uli' Atayal, the subject-only

restriction is illustrated for ex-situ *wh*-constructions (T. Chen 2010: 4, 8), ex-situ focus constructions (T.-T. Lin 2016: 68–73, 75), and gapped topicalization (T. Chen 2010: 21; Lu 2010: 180; T.-T. Lin 2016: 35–44). For Seediq, Chang (1997) (=C) and Tsukida (2009) (=T) independently document the subject-only restriction in Tgdaya and Truku Seediq, respectively, for head-external relatives (C: 142; T: 173–174), ex-situ *wh*-questions (C: 147–148, 169–170; T: 547–551), ex-situ focus constructions (C: 154–155; T: 281), and gapped topicalization (C: 166–167; T: 318).

Topic status The final property of Atayalic subjects that I highlight is their discourse topic status. I will again illustrate these effects with data from Squliq Atayal, but highlight prior works that document the same in other Atayalic varieties. Note that I limit my discussion here to the behavior of subjects that are non-pronominal and postverbal, and hence generally in clause-final position.

First, when addressing a question that clearly identifies a particular referent as the topic of discussion, speakers prefer to make that topic participant the subject. See the Squliq minimal pairs in (15–16) below. V. Chen (2017: 139–140) reports the same pattern of judgments in Tgdaya Seediq.

(15) **Asking about the agent** ⇒ **AV:** [Squliq]

Context: What is Yuraw doing?

a. Cyux m-anìq sehuy (qu') Yuraw.
AUX AV-eat taro NOM Yuraw
'Yuraw is eating taro.'

b. #Cyux niq-un na Yuraw (qu') sehuy.
AUX eat-PV GEN Yuraw NOM taro
'Yuraw is eating taro.'

(16) **Asking about the theme** ⇒ **PV:** [Squliq]

Context: What happened to the taro?

a. #Cyux m-anìq sehuy qasa (qu') Y.
AUX AV-eat taro DIST NOM Y.
'Yuraw is eating that taro.'

b. Cyux niq-un na Y. (qu') sehuy qasa.
AUX eat-PV GEN Y. NOM taro DIST
'Yuraw is eating that taro.'

As another measure of topichood, A. Liu (2017) reports on a corpus study of Squliq Atayal, concluding that subjects are associated with high rates of both givenness and aboutness, operationalized respectively through the statistical measures of referential distance and topic prominence following Givón 1983, 1994. S. Huang (2002) reports more ambiguous results from a similar corpus study of Tgdaya Seediq. Huang reports that agents are more frequently pro-dropped in AV, “suggesting that agents in [AV] are more topical than those in [NAV]” (p. 670), but at the same time reports that subject and voice choice

has little effect on the referential distance and topic prominence of the agent vs theme of bivalent verbs (pp. 682–685).

Second, when asking an in-situ *wh*-question, the *wh*-word cannot be the subject; see (17a). *Wh*-in-situ is possible, but only if it is a non-subject argument, as in (17b). *Wh*-questions are often expressed as ex-situ, *wh*-initial constructions as in (17c) or in (13–14) above; however, as noted above, the *wh*-phrases here are formally predicates of a matrix clause, rather than a moved subject.

(17) **Subject cannot be an interrogative *wh*:**

[Squiliq; B. Lin 2005: 39–40]

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>a. *Sij-on na Tali qu nanu?
 like-PV GEN Tali NOM what</p> | <p>b. S<m>oja nanu qu Tali?
 <AV>like what NOM Tali</p> |
| <p>c. Nanu qu [sij-on na Tali ____]?
 what NOM like-PV GEN Tali
 ‘What does Tali like?’</p> | |

This same restriction against in-situ interrogative *wh*-phrases in subject position has also been documented for Plngawan C’uli’ (C. Shih 2008: 89–90), Tgdaya Seediq (Chang 1997: 146–147, Aldridge 2004: 282), and Truku Seediq (Tsukida 2009: 317–318). See also L. Huang 1995b, 1996 and Huang et al. 1999 for many examples of ex-situ and in-situ *wh*-questions in Matu’uwal (C’uli’ Atayal) which accord with this generalization, but without negative data of ungrammatical subject in-situ *wh*-questions.

I conclude by noting that subjects in many Philippine-type Austronesian languages have been described as being associated with topicality. Among formal analyses that discuss and make use of this description, N. Richards 2000 on Tagalog, Pearson 2001, 2005 on Malagasy, and Aldridge 2004 on Seediq are important, earlier references. More recently, and following Aldridge’s description of Seediq *ka* as a “topic marker,” V. Chen (2017, 2025) takes such facts to motivate reanalyzing “nominative” morphology as in fact a form of topic marking that overrides underlying case morphology (see e.g. V. Chen 2025: 1884). My own proposal will pursue a different approach to explaining the morphology of subjects in Atayalic languages and their association with topichood.

3 Proposal

I now turn to my proposal for Atayalic syntax, with a particular emphasis on the various subjecthood properties observed above. Many aspects of my proposal will adopt assumptions from previous work on Atayalic and other Philippine-type languages, including a predicate-fronting derivation for verb-initial, subject-final word order (following Aldridge 1999 et seq on Seediq and Atayal and Holmer 2005 on

Seediq) and the idea that A- and $\bar{A}$ -features play a joint role in the determination of voice morphology (as in Chung 1982, 1994, 1998, Rackowski 2002, Rackowski & Richards 2005; V. Chen 2017, 2025, to appear), as well as assumptions regarding the structure of the verbal phase (as in Aldridge 2004, Erlewine & C. Lim 2023) and the derivation of clitic pronouns (Erlewine & Levin 2021).

The key, distinguishing innovation of my proposal here is my perspective on the nature of nominative marking. As illustrated above, subjects are associated with topic properties, but are also structurally reduced as compared to other, non-nominative case-marked arguments. I propose to take these morphological cues seriously, with nominatives reflecting a smaller structure (DPs) than other case-marked nominals (KPs). I then propose that the link between the form and function of subjects — i.e. nominative, DP form in sentence-final position and topic status — is enforced somewhat indirectly: Subjects are K-less DPs and DPs must be in the higher, CP phase of the clause, which a clause-peripheral topic position makes possible. Evidence for this perspective will come from the limited availability of nominative-marked non-subjects, which I introduce in section 4.

3.1 Nominal types and their distribution

I begin by discussing the structure of non-pronominal noun phrases in Atayalic. (I discuss clitic pronouns in section 3.4.) I propose that extended noun phrases in Atayalic may maximally project the functional projections $KP > DP > NP$. K is the locus of the non-nominative case markers, which I call genitive and oblique here, while D is the locus of what has traditionally been called nominative case marking.⁹ As the highest head in the functional sequence, I assume that K is a phase head.

(18) The functional sequence of the Atayalic extended NP:

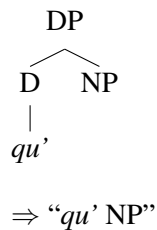
(K)	>	(D)	>	N
OBL/DAT		NOM		

As I showed in section 2.2 above, there is overt morphological evidence for this structure across the Atayalic group, although some details differ. I illustrate the structures that I propose for a few types of nominals in Squliq Atayal in (19) below. As reflected in these example structures, I generally assume that KP and DP layers are not projected when no overt head is present, although I return to the question of bare NPs below.

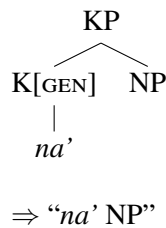
⁹ Other prenominal articles that do not cooccur with nominative-marking, such as the Squliq locative *te* and comitative *ki'* (Huang & Hayung 2011) may be treated as other K heads that are more restricted in their cooccurrence with D, or as prepositions. I set this question aside here.

(19) **Some example surface structures for Squliq Atayal nominals:**

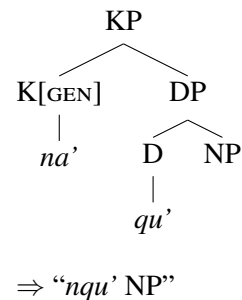
a. Nominative:



b. Genitive:



c. Genitive with D (GEN.D):



Nominal arguments are subject to a formal requirement to be “licensed” (see e.g. Chomsky 1981, 1986, Chomsky & Lasnik 1993), which is often implemented by claiming that noun phrases are born with an uninterpretable Case feature, [uCase], which must be checked via Agree with an appropriate licenser. Here I adopt a slightly more nuanced perspective (articulated in different forms in Bittner & Hale 1996 and Levin 2015) that the [uCase] feature is a requirement of K heads, and that nominals must project a KP or else require an alternative mode of licensing. In particular, Bittner & Hale (1996: 6) propose that K-less nominals must be in a local relationship with K’s “verbal counterpart, C.”¹⁰

Concretely, I will implement Bittner and Hale’s intuition with reference to the notion of a phase (Chomsky 2000, 2001). Following the analysis of Seediq in Aldridge 2004 (and of other Philippine-type languages in Rackowski & Richards 2005, Erlewine & Levin 2021, Hsieh 2020, 2025, Erlewine & C. Lim 2023, among others), I assume that clauses in Atayalic are bifurcated into two phases: *vP* and *CP*. I propose that nominals that are part of the *vP* phase at PF must project a KP (thereby requiring the checking and valuing of [uCase]), whereas nominals that are a part of the *CP* phase must be K-less DPs (thereby appearing in what we describe as nominative case). This phase-based distinction regarding the form of nominals echoes prior works that describe different default case values in different phases (see Baker 2015, as well as Austronesian-specific proposals of this form in T. Chen 2018 and Erlewine & C. Lim 2023).

In addition to nominals with prenominal articles, for which I propose the structures in (19) above, nominal arguments in Atayalic can also be bare. To account for such forms, I propose that K and D heads with NPs sisters may also have null allomorphs, although their availability and frequency of use may vary substantially across Atayalic varieties. For instance, oblique K in Tgdaya Seediq only has a null allomorph, while it is frequently null for non-subject themes in Squliq (see note 7). In contrast, based on prior descriptions, we may say that K and D heads are always overt in the well-studied Matu’uwal

¹⁰ More specifically, in GB terms, Bittner & Hale (1996) propose that a nominal “requires c-command and government by K or its verbal counterpart, C.” See also Lamontagne & Travis 1987 for an early articulation of the idea that KP and CP correspond to one another, between nominal and clausal domains, sharing the function that Wiltschko (2014) refers to as “linking.” See also Bliss’s (2013) discussion of Blackfoot proximate *-wa*, which further supports the idea of K/C parallelism.

variety of C’uli’ Atayal.

I propose that all nominal arguments are base-generated in thematic positions as KPs and, following work in the *wh*/case-agreement approach to Philippine-type syntax (see especially Kroeger 1990, Pearson 2001, 2005, Rackowski 2002, Rackowski & Richards 2005, V. Chen 2017, 2025, as well as Chung 1982, 1994, 1998 on Chamorro), all nominals are assigned case values which may later be obscured by the process of “subject promotion” that I describe in section 3.2 below. In particular, V. Chen (2017, 2025) presents evidence from Seediq that the oblique of themes may be described as structural accusative (extending also to ECM subjects, derived objects of raising-to-object-like predicates, and causees of productive causatives) and that the genitive of agents is structural nominative (extending to unaccusative themes).¹¹ I adopt this view here, although I continue to use the terms oblique (OBL) and genitive (GEN) for these case values, following more descriptive and typological work on these languages (see note 6 above). I annotate K heads which are born with [uCase] and then assigned oblique and genitive values as K[VOBL] and K[VGEN], respectively, with “v” indicating their having undergone a process of valuation. I abbreviate “Case:” where its omission will not cause confusion.

Following Bittner & Hale (1996: 6–7), K heads can also be generated with inherent case values: in particular, locations can be generated with an inherently oblique-valued K head (see 4a) and beneficiaries and instruments can be generated with an inherently genitive-valued K head (see 5a, 9). I will notate these K[iOBL] and K[iGEN], respectively, with “i” indicating their inherently valued status. I summarize these four different varieties of (structurally or inherently) valued K in (20):

(20) **Four varieties of valued K:**¹²

- | | | |
|---------------------------|---------|----------------------------------|
| a. agent | K[VGEN] | valued with nominative alignment |
| b. theme | K[VOBL] | valued with accusative alignment |
| c. location | K[iOBL] | inherent |
| d. beneficiary/instrument | K[iGEN] | inherent |

3.2 Voice alternations with K-Removal

Next, I introduce my approach to the syntax of voice alternations. My proposal will follow the current consensus position for the formal syntactic analysis of Philippine-type voice systems: that voice alter-

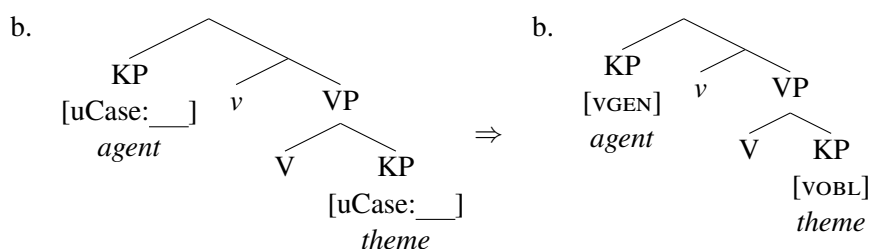
¹¹ This conclusion is also strengthened by the case-marking of arguments inside Truku Seediq gerunds, as discussed by Oiwa-Bungard (2017: 55ff). I briefly discuss such facts in section 4.2.

¹² The four varieties of valued K heads that I propose in (20a–d) correspond to what V. Chen (2017, 2025) refers to as case markers CM₁ and CM₂ and prepositions P₁ and P₂, respectively. I prefer my own description here for Atayalic for two reasons. First, describing these forms as CM₁/CM₂/P₁/P₂ obscures the fact that what V. Chen would call CM₁ and P₂ (in 20a,d) both realize the same genitive article forms and CM₂ and P₁ (in 20b,c) both realize the same oblique article forms. Second, I am aware of no evidence in Atayalic for distinguishing between the first two as “case markers” and the latter two as “prepositions,” except that the former’s case features are valued during the derivation whereas the latter have inherent values. However, I will acknowledge that this is primarily a matter of notational choice and that the core of my proposal below can be maintained even if we adopt V. Chen’s style of description for the non-nominative articles.

nations and verbal voice morphology are associated with the head of the clause-medial, verbal phase, and in particular, that the subject is always the highest nominal in the verbal phase (see e.g. Aldridge 2004, Rackowski & Richards 2005, Erlewine, Levin & Van Urk 2020, Erlewine & Levin 2021, Erlewine & C. Lim 2023, Hsieh 2025). My proposal however differs from existing phase-based proposals for Philippine-type voice systems in the derivational procedure involved in voice alternations. Instead of simply moving the subject to the phase edge and Agreeing with it in its Case value, I propose that the phase head v removes the K layer of the subject, inspired by the “case incorporation” proposal of Kroeger 1990 and related allusions to “preposition incorporation” in Guilfoyle, Hung & Travis 1992, as well as recent work on the theory of structure removal operations (especially Müller 2017, 2018 et seq).

I begin by discussing the internal structure of the verbal phase. As an illustration, consider the organization of a basic transitive verb as in (21) below. The theme is built as the sister to V and the agent is built as the specifier of v . (Note that this structure in (21b) does not yet reflect a complete vP , due to additional formal requirements of the phase head v , which I discuss below.)

(21) **KPs are base-generated within vP and then Case-valued:**



All nominal arguments are built as KPs and then are Case-valued if necessary. As noted above, following V. Chen (2017, 2025), I assume that “genitive” and “oblique” cases are assigned with nominative/accusative alignment to KPs that lack Case values; see (21b).¹³ Other KPs with inherent Case values could be introduced as adjuncts or with additional functional structure; these may then be candidates for LV or CV subjecthood.

After completion of its thematic requirements, as in (21), formal requirements of the phase head v trigger the sequence of operations that I will describe together as “subject promotion.” Specifically, these reflect three featural annotations on v : (i) an unvalued Case feature, [uCase: __]; (ii) a feature triggering removal of a K head, $[-K^0-]$ ¹⁴; and (iii) the standard $\bar{A}$ -edge feature (which I notate $[\bullet\bar{A}\bullet]$) on phase heads, which supports intermediate movement. I assume the principle of Multitasking as defined in Van Urk & Richards 2015 (22), which suggests that v will prefer to identify a single goal in order to satisfy

¹³ My proposal is compatible with this nominative/accusative-aligned Case valuation being mediated by the functional heads in the verbal extended projection within vP , or else reflecting a dependent case calculus implemented via direct KP–KP Agree relations (see e.g. Branen 2019, Clem 2022). What my proposal is *not* compatible with is Case-valuation depending upon functional heads outside of the vP phase, or for it to follow the process of subject promotion, described below.

all of these requirements together.

(22) **Multitasking:**

(Van Urk & Richards 2015: 132)

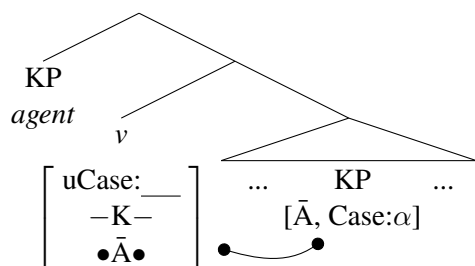
“At every step in a derivation, if a probe can trigger two operations A and B, and the features checked by A are a superset of those checked by B, the grammar prefers A.”

I follow V. Chen (2017, 2025) and Hsieh (2020, 2025) in the view that the subject is distinguished from other nominals by bearing an $\bar{A}$ -feature: more specifically, a topic [TOP] or relative operator [REL] feature. Due to Multitasking (22), probing by v for these features (i–iii) will identify the subject $\bar{A}$ -KP, which has a Case value (for (i)), K category feature (for (ii)), and an $\bar{A}$ -feature (for (iii)).

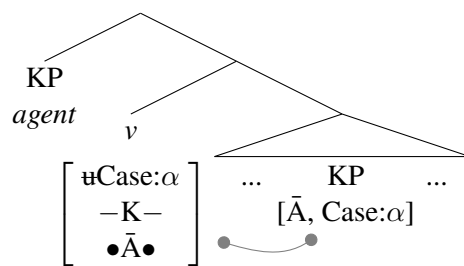
I will illustrate the process and results of subject promotion first in Non-Actor Voice clauses and then discuss Actor Voice derivations below. As noted above, probing by v for these three features will identify the $\bar{A}$ -bearing KP in its domain, which will become the subject; see (23a). Then, v Agrees with the goal KP in its Case value (23b), removes the K head from the goal KP, leaving the DP with an $\bar{A}$ -feature in its place (23c), and then moves the resulting $\bar{A}$ -DP to become an outer specifier of v P (23d).

(23) **Subject promotion with Case agreement and K-Removal, in Non-Actor Voice:**

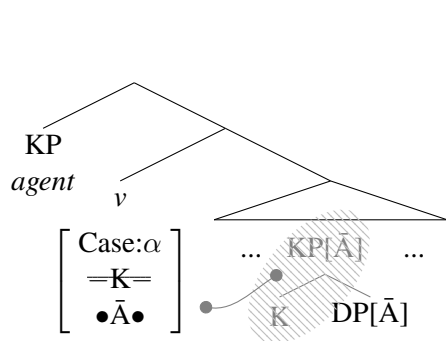
a. v probes with Multitasking:



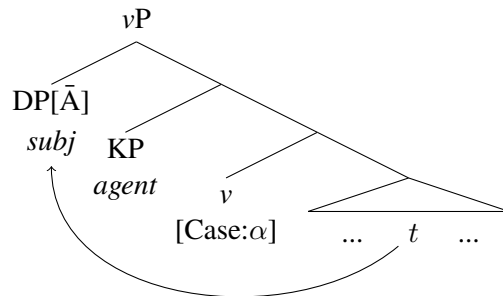
b. Agree in Case:



c. Remove the subject's K head:



d. Move the resulting $\bar{A}$ -DP:



The realization of the v head depends upon and varies with the Case value that it copies back from the subject KP. I schematize these morphological realizations in (24) below, which correspond one-to-one

¹⁴ On structure removal, see Müller 2017, 2018, Hewett to appear, and citations there. Features of the form $[-X^0-]$ trigger the operation Remove targeting a X head. The proposed derivation here is also reminiscent of the “peeling” effects of movement on morphological case, as proposed in Caha 2009.

with the four varieties of K in (20) above. I abbreviate the surface forms associated with each voice here as *AV*, *PV*, etc.

(24) **Four possible realizations of v , depending on the Case value copied back:**

- a. $v[\text{VGEN}] \leftrightarrow \text{AV}$
- b. $v[\text{VOBL}] \leftrightarrow \text{PV}$
- c. $v[\text{iOBL}] \leftrightarrow \text{LV}$
- d. $v[\text{iGEN}] \leftrightarrow \text{CV}$

I assume that the lexical verb head-moves up to v , resulting in voice morphology on the verb; see (24). Note that the outer specifier of vP is an intermediate movement position, and not its final landing site. I discuss the movements that yield subject-final word order in the following section (§3.3). The verbal complex will head-move further up out of vP — at least to an Asp head just above vP , following Aldridge 2004: 202–206 on Seediq — ensuring that the lexical verb will proceed all arguments in vP .

The idea that Philippine-type voice affixes realize the case value corresponding to the subject is shared with many prior works on Philippine-type syntax; see especially Pearson 2001, 2005, Rackowski 2002, Rackowski & Richards 2005, and V. Chen 2017, 2021, to appear, which in turn all echo the discussion of Chamorro *wh*-agreement in Chung 1982, 1994, 1998. However, these prior works in the case/*wh*-agreement tradition do not propose that the subject is structurally reduced as compared to other arguments, let alone that this is a result of the derivational syntax of the voice alternation. The only precursor to this aspect of my proposal that I am aware of is Kroeger 1990, a short unpublished manuscript on the syntax of Kimaragang Dusun, a Philippine-type language of northeast Borneo. There, he suggests that the case marker (represented as a K head, citing Lamontagne & Travis 1987) separates from the subject and incorporates into Infl, resulting in voice morphology on the verb and a DP subject.¹⁵ However, in this manuscript, it is not clear how or why the resulting DP subject without K then appears with nominative marking. In contrast, the idea that subjects have had their K heads removed naturally accords with the idea that nominatives are structurally reduced (DPs) as compared to other case-marked nominals, which receives independent motivation from the morphology of Atayalic prenominal articles.

The structure of vP differs slightly in cases where the agent KP that is base-generated as the specifier of vP is itself the subject, as in most cases of AV clauses.¹⁶ In such cases, illustrated in (25) below, there

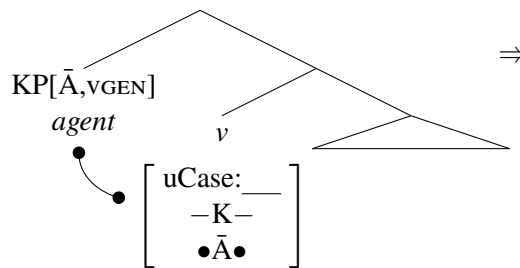
¹⁵ Guilfoyle, Hung & Travis 1992 makes a brief, similar suggestion in relation to the derivation of Circumstantial Voice (CV) in Malagasy (footnote 7 on page 382, and again on page 412): The subject is base-generated as a prepositional argument whose preposition undergoes incorporation into the verbal complex (citing the Baker 1988 analysis of applicatives), and the resulting preposition-less nominal becomes the subject. Kroeger (1990) describes his own case incorporation view as a refinement and extension to Guilfoyle, Hung & Travis's (1992) P-incorporation (citing a prepublication manuscript), criticizing the P-incorporation approach as only applying to a subset of voices (i.e., LV and CV here) and not to agent and theme subjects in AV or PV. See also Paul 2000: 114–120 for both theoretical and empirical concerns regarding the analysis of Malagasy CV as involving P-incorporation.

¹⁶ Recall that AV is also used when the subject is the theme of an unaccusative predicate. In such cases, the subject KP will be in

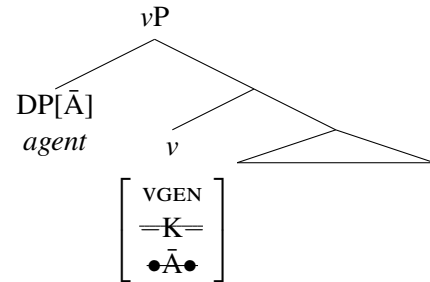
is no goal in the probe's c-command domain that maximally satisfies its Multitasking probe, and so the probe considers its specifier via “cyclic expansion” (see e.g. Béjar & Rezac 2009); see (25). The v head Agrees with the agent in Case and Removes its K head, and trivially satisfies its $\bar{A}$ -edge feature. See (25b).

(25) **Subject promotion of local agent with Case agreement and K-Removal, in AV:**

a. v probes with Multitasking:



b. The result of Agree and Remove:



Finally, recall that v is a phase head. I assume the Phase Impenetrability Condition (Chomsky 2000: 108, 2001: 13), which claims that only the “edge” of the phase (its head and specifiers) are accessible for syntactic operations outside of the phase. Notably, the derivations above predict that only one nominal (the subject) is available for higher operations in AV clauses (see 25), whereas two nominals (both the subject and the non-subject agent) will be accessible in NAV clauses (see 23). Erlewine & Levin (2021) argue for precisely this type of difference between the syntax of AV and NAV clauses in Philippine-type Austronesian languages, based on the attested inventories of second-position clitic pronouns in these languages. I return to this feature of my account, and the derivation of pronominal clitics, in section 3.4 below.

3.3 Subjects in topic position with predicate-fronting

Recall from sections 2.1 and 2.3 above that non-pronominal subjects in Atayalic languages are strongly associated with sentence-final position and topic interpretation. I propose that this subject-final word order reflects the movement of the subject to a high position, followed by the remainder of the sentence (the predicate) moving to an even higher position, as has been previously proposed for Seediq by Aldridge (2002, 2004, 2013, 2019) and Holmer (2005) and for Matu’uwal C’uli’ by T. Chen (2010).

Concretely, I propose that there is a Topic head (or simply “Top”) in the clause periphery. Non-pronominal subjects move to this position, which will lead to their clause-final position. This description follows prior work on Seediq: Aldridge (2002, 2004) describes the relevant movement as targeting a

the c-command domain of v and hence the derivation will proceed as in (23) above, but the morphology on the verb will reflect $v[vGEN]$ (24a) and so it too will result in a morphologically AV clause.

In the basic case, Top will take a projection I call TP as its complement and TopP in turn will be sister to a higher head F, which attracts the remnant TP. I illustrate these two movement steps in (26):

a.

b.

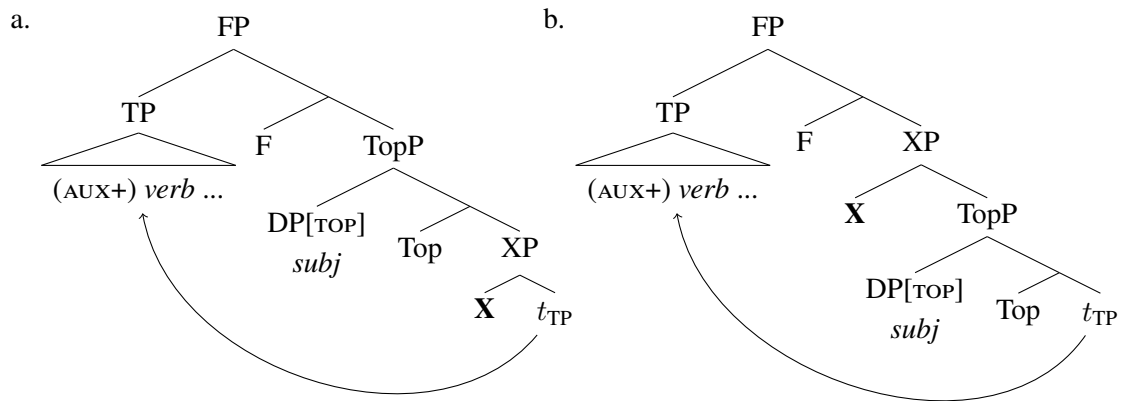
Based on this proposal, the sentence-final subject is unique among postverbal phrases in being in the CP phase. All other arguments will stay within ν P, which is fronted as part of TP and hence precedes the subject. Recall as well that I have proposed that noun phrases must be KPs inside ν P, but K-less DPs in the CP phase (§3.1). K-Removal in the process of subject promotion (see (23) above) makes the subject K-less, in addition to placing it at the ν P phase edge. A full noun phrase subject therefore can and must have been generated with a D layer and then move to Spec,TopP. This explains the surface correlation between nominative case (analyzed as K-less DPs) and sentence-final linear position.¹⁷

¹⁷ I am aware of just one exception to the sentence-final position of subjects: In Matu'uwal (C'uli') AV clauses, “*agent/subject* < *theme*” order is attested, although still dispreferred (L. Huang 1995a: 23, D. Liu 2011: 42). I tentatively suggest that Matu'uwal AV clauses exceptionally allow for the K-less DP subject to stay in-situ, in Spec,vP, involving only Agreement with (or covert movement to) Top. See (i), where I indicate the dispreferred option with [?].

- [C'uli'; based on T. Chen 2010: 28]

analyze them as heads in the functional sequence above the target of predicate-fronting (TP). Predicate-fronting to clause-initial position strands these particles in clause-final position. I give a simplified possible account for such particles (here represented by X) in (27a).

(27) **The derivation of clause-final and pre-subject particles:**



Holmer also suggests that this type of analysis can be easily adapted for related predicate-initial and subject-final languages with grammatical particles that appear specifically in pre-subject position as well, such as the interrogative particle *ve* in Malagasy (paul2001a). See (27b).¹⁸

The distribution of interrogative particles in Squliq reflects the availability of both structures in (27). Although interrogative particles in Atayal are generally described as appearing in clause-final position, for the Squliq Atayal speakers that I had the fortune of working with (from Fuhsing township, Taoyuan county), the interrogative particle *ga'* may precede or follow the subject, but cannot precede non-subject arguments; see (28).¹⁹

(28) **Interrogative *ga'* must be in pre-subject or sentence-final position:**

[Squliq]

Cyux m-aniq {**ga'*} yutak {*ga'*} qu' Yuraw {*ga'*}?
 AUX AV-eat orange Q NOM Yuraw Q
 'Is Yuraw eating oranges?'

I suggest that this optionality in placement reflects that there are two options for the head that hosts the particle *ga'*, below or above TopP, reflecting the X head options in (27a) and (27b).

¹⁸ Both derivations sketched in (27) are simplified as compared to what Holmer (2005) presents. Holmer also considers the ordering of multiple clause-final particles when they cooccur, and therefore suggests that higher layers of the functional sequence undergo roll-up movement, following TP fronting. I simplify the presentation here for expository purposes, as I will only make reference to evidence involving a single particle (X) at a time.

¹⁹ See also Kao 2010, Yu 2015, and C. Lin 2018 for discussion of similar particles in C'uli' Atayal, which are generally clause-final but may also appear in some clause-medial positions. Unfortunately, the evidence presented there is insufficient for determining whether the analysis I pursue here for Squliq *ga'* (as reflecting the X positions in (27a) or (27b)) also extends to these other cases or not.

3.4 Clauses without final subjects

There are two common ways that a clause will lack a clause-final subject: if the subject is a second-position clitic pronoun or if it is $\bar{A}$ -extracted. I propose that in both of these classes of examples, Spec,TopP is simply unoccupied. I discuss each type of structure here in turn.

Clitic pronouns I take the view that clitic pronouns reflect (head) movement of the pronoun to T, following Erlewine & Levin's (2021) general proposal for clitic pronouns in Philippine-type languages. I assume that clitic pronouns are built with a reduced structure: specifically, as D heads without NP restrictors (Postal 1966, Elbourne 2001, 2005), with a K layer on top. A probe on T probes for all accessible nominals (at the ν P phase edge) and optionally head-moves their outermost head (cf. long head movement of D in e.g. Roberts 2010, Preminger 2019).²⁰ For the subject, this will be its D head, as subjects lack K following subject promotion. For a non-subject agent, this will be the K[vGEN] head, perhaps with D head-moved to it; I assume more generally that the K[vGEN] head cannot head-move unless it has a DP sister. (Here I concentrate on the derivation of clitic pronouns, with no NP restrictors, but I will discuss the possibility of clitic-doubling derived by this proposal in section 4 below.)

Notice that Phase Impenetrability ensures that this process of cliticization can only ever apply to subjects and non-subject agents. As Erlewine & Levin (2021) note, this accords with a typological generalization: Philippine-type Austronesian languages have only at most two sets of second-position clitic pronouns, for subjects (nominative) and for non-subject agents (genitive). They argue that this is explained by, and in turn supports, the idea that the verbal phase has just one specifier in AV (the subject, often agentive) but two in NAV (the subject and the non-subject agent), as in my proposal in (23–25) above (see also Aldridge 2004, Rackowski & Richards 2005, Erlewine & C. Lim 2023).

I assume that T hosts the highest auxiliary, or else the lexical verb itself in the absence of any auxiliaries. The clitic pronouns that head-move to T therefore appear as second-position enclitics following the word in T. See examples in (6) above.

$\bar{A}$ -extraction constructions Following Aldridge's (2002, 2004, 2013) discussion of ex-situ focus and *wh*-constructions in Seediq (see also Paul 2001, Potsdam 2009), I will treat all $\bar{A}$ -constructions as involving a null, relative operator. Formally, I treat the null operator as an unpronounced, bare NP with [REL], but like all nominal arguments it will be base-generated with a K layer: [_{KP} K Op_N] (cf. 19b). The null operator must ultimately be moved alone (as an NP) and then triggers predicate abstraction semantics (see e.g. Heim & Kratzer 1998: ch. 5).

²⁰ I describe this head-movement operation as optional, as it will generally not apply to nominals containing NP material. (Doing so will lead to clitic doubling, which I take up in section 4.) For reduced pronouns not containing an NP, I assume that this head-movement must take place as there is no means of realizing the pronoun without incorporation into a host word.

In $\bar{A}$ -constructions, I assume a high head in the clause periphery (C) probes for [REL]. Due to Phase Impenetrability, only the subject and non-subject agent (in NAV clauses) will be accessible for this probe. If the subject is a null operator, it will be a bare NP following subject promotion, so $\bar{A}$ -movement targeting [REL] will successfully move the operator NP alone. If the non-subject agent is a null operator, it will still be wrapped in its K layer. As abstraction requires movement of the null operator alone, we cannot simply attract the operator-containing KP. Nor can the operator be subextracted from KP, due to the phasehood of KP. In summary, then, even though both subjects and non-subject agents can be at the lower phase edge, $\bar{A}$ -constructions can only target subjects due to their structural differences.

We should also consider the possibility of the probe on T that derives clitic pronouns targeting the agent KP, head-moving its K head and hence making its contents accessible. However, recall that I have proposed that the derivation of genitive pronominal clitics involves movement of K that is in a local relationship with D, and cannot be the result of the movement of K without a DP sister. I furthermore assume that null operators cannot project a D layer, due to their predicational semantics (see e.g. Stowell 1991, Longobardi 1994, and the derivation of relativization in Kayne 1994 where pivots are D-less NPs).

The inability of null operators to project higher functional projections that can feed cliticization (on the theory here, specifically D) receives indirect support from $\bar{A}$ -constructions in Kapampangan. Kapampangan is a Philippine language that, unlike most other Philippine-type languages, consistently clitic-doubles all full noun phrase arguments. However, arguments targeted by $\bar{A}$ -movement are not clitic doubled. See (29).

(29) **$\bar{A}$ -operators do not feed clitic doubling in Kapampangan:**

[Kapampangan; C. M. Richards 1971: 258, 276]

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>a. E =ya masikan ing lalaki.
 NEG =NOM.3sg strong NOM man
 ‘The man is not strong.’</p> | <p>b. Ninu ing [e masikan ____]?
 who NOM NEG strong
 ‘Who is not strong?’</p> |
|--|--|

Notice that I do *not* assume that subject $\bar{A}$ -movement proceeds through Spec,TopP, the position of postverbal non-pronominal subjects. When the subject is an $\bar{A}$ -operator or a clitic pronoun, it will instead move directly to C or T, respectively, leaving the topic position unoccupied. This possibility of leaving Spec,TopP open will play a crucial role in my discussion below.

4 Non-subjects with nominative marking

On my proposal for case and voice in Atayalic above, nominative case and the high, sentence-final position are both not directly linked to subjecthood. As a consequence of the process of subject

promotion, subjects lose their K layers, and hence must end up as a DP in the CP phase, which the topic position allows them to do. Nominative then reflects the subject's status as a K-less DP which ends up in sentence-final position due to predicate fronting across the topic position.

My approach here opens up the possibility that other nominals might also be hosted in the topic position and hence be in nominative case and in sentence-final position. In this section, I present evidence of precisely this possibility. I first discuss nominative non-subject agents and their analysis in section 4.1, and then discuss some attested extensions and parameters of microvariation in section 4.2.

4.1 Nominative non-subject agents with genitive clitic doubling

I first present what I believe to be the most common form of nominative non-subjects: non-subject agents that are doubled by a genitive clitic pronoun, in NAV clauses without postverbal subjects. By way of example, consider the Squliq theme *wh*-question in (30) below. This example involves $\bar{A}$ -extraction of the theme, which is the subject as predicted by the verb's PV morphology and in accordance with the subject-only restriction on $\bar{A}$ -extraction that we have observed above. However, there is also a nominative-marked postverbal argument, *Yuraw*, which is interpreted as the agent and must be doubled by a genitive clitic pronoun.

(30) **Nominative non-subject agent in theme *wh*-question:** [Squliq]

Nanu (qu') [cyux *(=nya) niq-un ____ qu' Yuraw]?
 what NOM AUX =GEN.3sg eat-PV NOM Yuraw
 'What is Yuraw eating?'

Nominative non-subject agents are also possible where the subject is itself a clitic pronoun, as in (31). Notice that there are two nominative-coded expressions here (the first-singular clitic pronoun and *Tali*) but the sentence is unambiguously 'Tali saw me' and not 'I saw Tali.' In other words, the postverbal nominative full noun phrase must be interpreted as associated with the genitive pronoun, which reflects the predicted coding for a non-subject agent.

(31) **Nominative non-subject agent with subject clitic pronoun:** [Squliq]

Wal =saku *(=nya) kt-an qu' Tali.
 AUX =NOM.1sg =GEN.3sg see-LV NOM Tali
 'Tali saw me.'

Nominative non-subject agents have also been documented in Seediq by various scholars. Just as I have shown for Squliq above, such agents "must be resumed by a pronoun" (Aldridge 2004: 215),

which is always a genitive clitic pronoun. I present one such example from Truku Seediq in (32), with its non-nominative agent baseline. Note that Truku lacks genitive and oblique prenominal articles, but I reproduce the source’s glossing which indicates these values. I present additional Seediq examples in section 4.2 below.

(32) **Nominative non-subject agent in Seediq:** [Seediq; Tsukida 2009: 323]

- a. Se-pehapuy =ku qesurux Kumu.
 CV-cook =NOM.1sg fish(OBL) Kumu(GEN)
- b. Se-pehapuy =ku =na qesurux ka Kumu.
 CV-cook =NOM.1sg =GEN.3sg fish(OBL) NOM Kumu
 ‘Kumu cooked (the) fish for me.’

In Squliq Atayal, nominative non-subject agents are not possible when the subject (as determined by the choice of voice marking) is itself a postverbal nominative-marked full noun phrase. See (33) below, where I present a PV baseline (33a) and then the attempted nominative-marking with clitic doubling in (33b). In section 4.2, I will show that this requirement for no postverbal subject is subject to variation.

(33) **Nominative non-subject agent cannot cooccur with subject NP:**²¹ [Squliq]

- a. Niq-un na’ Yuraw qu’ sehuy qani.
 eat-PV GEN Yuraw NOM taro PROX
 ‘Yuraw is eating this taro.’
- b. *Niq-un =nya {qu’ Yuraw} (qu’) sehuy qani {qu’ Yuraw}.
 eat-PV =GEN.3sg NOM Yuraw NOM taro PROX

Analysis The examples above motivate the following analysis. In Squliq, just when Spec,TopP is left unoccupied, it is possible to host the non-subject agent there. As a noun phrase in the CP phase, then, the agent must be a K-less DP and hence appear with nominative marking. Furthermore, I propose that the obligatory genitive clitic pronoun is what allows the non-subject agent to become a K-less DP.

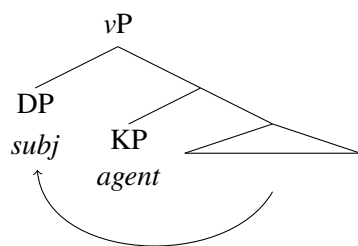
I schematize this derivational process in (34) below. I start with the NAV vP phase structure in (34a), from (23) above. Recall that T probes for accessible nominals, which here will be the subject and non-subject agent, and then optionally head-moves each goal’s highest head. I propose that in Squliq, when

²¹ As noted above (see (7)), the subject’s nominative marker *qu’* can be dropped in Squliq, but (34b) is ungrammatical even with the subject’s *qu’* article dropped. This suggests that the relevant constraint is not a surface dispreference for two overt nominative markers in an utterance, as reported by C. Shih (2008: 20) for PIngawan C’uli’ and by Oiwa-Bungard (2017: 60) for Truku Seediq.

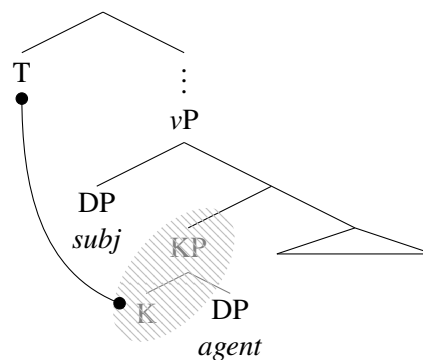
the head K undergoes long head-movement to T, the goal's original K head is Removed; see (34b).²² This leaves another K-less nominal at the phase edge; see (34c). As nominals within the ν P phase must be full KPs, the resulting non-subject agent must move out of ν P, into the CP phase. Assuming that the subject itself was a clitic pronoun (head-moving fully into T) or will $\bar{A}$ -move to Spec,CP (not illustrated in (34)), Spec,TopP will be available to attract the non-subject agent; see (34d). Finally, TP predicate-fronting takes place (also not illustrated here). The agent must have been originally generated with a D layer, so it can be licensed in the CP phase as a K-less DP, and thus appears with nominative marking.

(34) **Genitive pronoun cliticization Removes the agent's K head:**

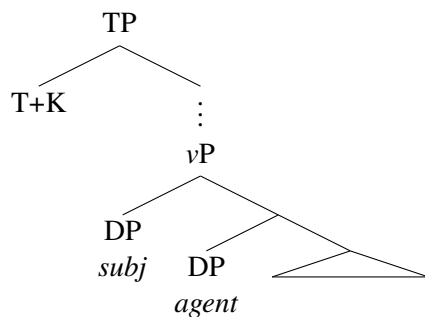
a. Build NAV ν P:



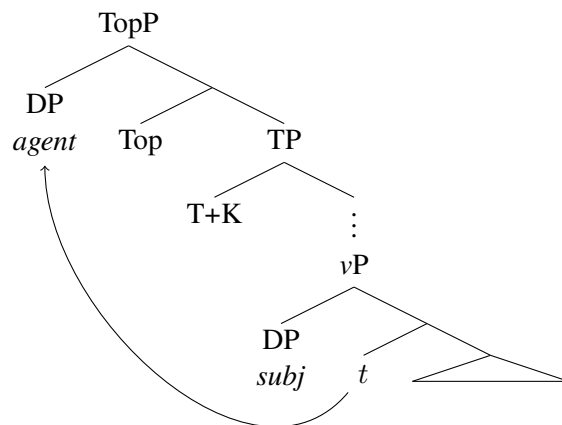
b. T attracts and Removes K head:



c. Result:



d. Movement to Spec,TopP:



In sum, this proposal successfully explains the availability of non-subject agents with nominative case, with obligatory genitive clitic doubling. Such derivations are limited in Sqliq to clauses where the subject itself does not occupy the high, sentence-final position, which I analyze as the consequence of Sqliq TopP being limited to hosting one specifier.

Predictions A prediction of my analysis is that nominative-marked non-subjects should be in the high, sentence-final position normally associated with non-pronominal subjects. Recall that the Sqliq

²² Whether head-movement of K obligatorily triggers K-Removal on the goal KP is a point of variation, as I discuss in section 4.2 below.

interrogative particle *ga'* can precede clause-final subjects, but normally cannot precede non-subject arguments; see (35a). However, *ga'* can precede nominative non-subject agents; see (35b). As I argued in section 3.3 above, this suggests that the nominative agent in (35b) is structurally high, outside of the domain of predicate fronting (TP), unlike the genitive agent in (35a).

(35) **Interrogative *ga'* shows nominative non-subject agent is high:** [Squliq]

- a. Kt-an =simu {**ga'*} na' Tali {*ga'*}?
 see-LV =NOM.2pl GEN Tali Q
- b. Kt-an =simu =nya {*ga'*} qu' Tali {*ga'*}?
 see-LV =NOM.2pl =GEN.3sg Q NOM Tali
 'Did Tali see you?'

We also expect nominative-marked non-subjects to be associated with topic status. Recall that one reflex of topic status is an inability to host an interrogative *wh*-phrase. (See example (17) in section 2.3 above, where this was presented as a subject property.) Tsukida (2009) notes that this restriction also extends to nominative non-subject agents in Truku Seediq:

(36) **Nominative non-subject cannot be a *wh*-word:** [Seediq; Tsukida 2009: 325]

- *Se-pehapuy =ku =na qexurux ka 'ima?
 CV-cook =NOM.1sg =GEN.3sg fish(OBL) NOM who
 Intended: 'Who cooked (the) fish for me?'

Finally, I revisit the relationship between nominative-marking and $\bar{A}$ -extraction. Previously, we had seen that $\bar{A}$ -extraction is limited to subjects, but subject status also appeared to be one-to-one with nominative case. Given the availability of nominative-marking non-subject agents, under particular conditions, it is important to see whether such agents can also be $\bar{A}$ -extracted. The answer is negative. Consider the pair of examples in (37). (37a) reproduces example (31) from above as a baseline, where *Tali* is a nominative non-subject agent. Example (37b) illustrates the prediction of $\bar{A}$ -extraction of a non-subject agent from an otherwise equivalent clause. The ungrammaticality of (37b) shows that the availability of $\bar{A}$ -extraction truly tracks subjecthood, rather than nominative-marking.

(37) **Non-subject agent doubled by genitive clitic cannot be $\bar{A}$ -extracted:** [Squliq]

a. Wal =saku =nya kt-an qu Tali. =(31)

AUX =NOM.1sg =GEN.3sg see-LV NOM Tali

‘Tali saw me.’

b. *Ima (qu) [wal =saku =nya kt-an ____]?

who NOM AUX =NOM.1sg =GEN.3sg see-LV

Intended: ‘Who saw me?’

Tsukida (2009: 324) also notes that, in Truku Seediq, the possibility of nominative-marking non-subject agents doubled by a genitive clitic cannot feed relativization, in line with the Squliq data point in (37).

This restriction on $\bar{A}$ -extraction is predicted by my account above. I have proposed that $\bar{A}$ -extractions in Atayalic are all null operator constructions, and that null operators are NPs that cannot host a D layer. Genitive clitic pronouns involve K[_{VGEN}] in the context of a local D head, and hence we predict that the K head of a null operator cannot be Removed via genitive clitic doubling. In contrast, K-Removal in the process of subject promotion does not depend on the presence or absence of a D head, making it compatible with null operators that then undergo $\bar{A}$ -extraction.

4.2 Extensions and parameters of microvariation

I consider the particular variety of nominative-marked non-subject described above in section 4.1 — that is, nominative-marked non-subject agents with genitive clitic doubling, in the absence of a postverbal subject — to be a previously underappreciated but common possibility across Atayalic.²³ In contrast, in this section, I will discuss related constructions which can be described as minor variants thereof. My analysis above can easily be extended to these other possibilities and helps us make sense of the attested points of variation, which in turn further motivates the analytic approach above.

Multiple nominative noun phrases The first extension I describe is the possibility, attested in some Seediq varieties, for nominative non-subject agents to cooccur with a postverbal subject. Aldridge (2004) presents the following minimal pair from Tgdaya Seediq. In example (38b), there are two postverbal nominative-marked phrases: the theme ‘friend’ (the subject of the PV clause) followed by the non-subject agent *Pawan*.

²³ Although this construction has only been documented in the Squliq variety from my own fieldwork and in a range of Seediq varieties, I am not aware of any work on any Atayalic variety which explicitly shows that the construction in section 4.1 is not possible; it is simply the case that constructions of this form have generally not been investigated. Therefore, although I cannot claim with certainty that such constructions are available in all Atayalic varieties, the available evidence is compatible with this possibility.

(38) **Nominative non-subject agent together with nominative subject:**

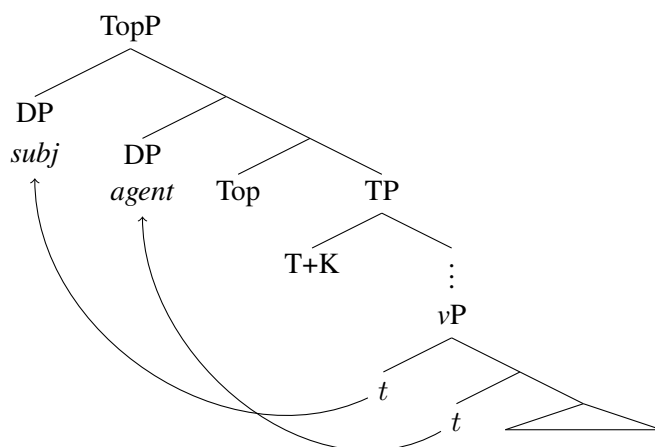
[Seediq; Aldridge 2004: 44–45]

- a. Wada bube-un na Pawan ka dangi=na.
 AUX hit-PV GEN Pawan NOM friend=GEN.3sg
 ‘Pawan hit his friend.’
- b. Wada =na bube-un ka dangi=na ka Pawan-ni.
 AUX =GEN.3sg hit-PV NOM friend=GEN.3sg NOM Pawan-DEF
 ‘Pawan hit his friend.’

Additional Tgdaya Seediq examples of this form in (38b) are also found in Holmer 1996: 128, Su 1997: 249, and Aldridge 2004: 77, 215. For Truku Seediq, Tsukida (2009: 324) claims that such simultaneous multiple nominative structures are possible for some but not all of her speakers.

My analysis for the derivation of nominative non-subject agents in Squliq, in (34) above, can be easily adapted to these facts here. I propose that the Seediq speakers that allow for multiple postverbal nominatives of the form in (38b) have Top heads that can attract and host multiple accessible DP topic specifiers. See (39). On this proposal, the observed variation between my Squliq speakers and the various Seediq speakers who allow multiple nominative phrases then echoes the well-studied difference between languages with single *wh*-movement and multiple *wh*-movement in multiple *wh* questions (see e.g. N. Richards 1997).

(39) **Hosting two nominatives in Spec,TopP:**



In particular, when multiple DPs are moved, I propose that they do so in an order-preserving fashion (perhaps via Richards’ “tucking-in”), as illustrated in (39). This proposal accurately derives the fact, noted by Aldridge (2004: 44) and Tsukida (2009: 324), that subjects must precede non-subject agents in these constructions with multiple postverbal nominatives. For instance, example (38b) unambiguously

expresses that ‘Pawan hit his friend,’ not the other way around.

Seediq gerunds A second extension of the behavior above is the availability of nominative non-pivot agents in Seediq gerunds, as documented by Oiwa-Bungard (2017). Gerunds in Seediq at first glance resemble verbal clauses, but have a number of important differences. First, there is no voice alternation in gerunds. Some gerundive morphology appears to be cognate to verbal voice morphology, but they have different functions. For instance, the *-an* suffix in (40) is equal in form to the LV suffix but here indicates non-future tense (*ibid.*: 44ff). Second, arguments inside gerunds generally receive case as follows: the agent of transitives and the sole argument of unaccusatives and unergatives all appear with genitive case, transitive themes bear oblique case, and there is no nominative-marked phrase (*ibid.*: 55ff). See example (40a). Against this background, Oiwa-Bungard shows that the agent inside a gerund can optionally be nominative-marked, obligatorily doubled by a genitive clitic pronoun; see (40b).

(40) **Nominative non-subject agent in gerund:** [Seediq; Oiwa-Bungard 2017: 58]

- a. Tru jiyax [q<n>rap-an knan pais].
three day capture<PFV>-GER.NFUT OBL.1sg enemy(GEN)
- b. Tru jiyax [q<n>rap-an *(=dha) knan ka pais].
three day capture<PFV>-GER.NFUT =GEN.3pl OBL.1sg NOM enemy
‘It has been three days since the enemies caught me.’ (lit. ‘The enemies’ having caught me is three days.’)

My proposal above can be easily extended to address these behaviors of Seediq gerunds. First, I note that the case-marking of arguments inside gerunds is exactly what we predict on my account if an environment simply does not choose any argument for promotion to subject: following V. Chen (2017, 2025), “genitive” is assigned with nominative alignment and “oblique” is assigned with accusative alignment. Second, the availability of a nominative non-subject agent as in (40b) supports my view that nominative-marking is *not* specifically tied to subjecthood; instead, it reflects a structural reduction that may be the result of subject promotion (not operative in gerunds) or else of genitive clitic doubling which also triggers K-Removal. Assuming the existence of a Topic or similar layer at the edge of gerunds which can host a K-less DP, we explain the availability of the nominative agents with genitive clitic doubling as in (40b).

Clitic doubling without K-Removal One ingredient of my analysis for nominative non-subject agents with genitive clitic doubling above was that, in Squiliq, head-movement of a nominal’s outermost functional head would result in its Removal. (See (34) above.) This explains the ungrammaticality of

a non-subject agent being clitic-doubled by a genitive pronoun and also staying in-situ as a genitive-marked noun phrase, as in (41) below.²⁴

- (41) **Ungrammatical in-situ clitic-doubling in Squliq:** [Squliq; A. Liu 2004: 22]

*Kit-an =**nya'** (na') Sayun qu' ngarux qasa.
 see-LV =GEN.3sg GEN Sayun NOM bear DIST
 Intended: 'Sayun saw that bear.'

The obligatoriness of Removal together with cliticization is a point of (micro)variation. Chang (1997) reports that for his Tgdaya Seediq speakers, non-subject agents can optionally be clitic-doubled while retaining their original genitive marking; see (42).²⁵ I analyze this as reflecting an option for these Seediq speakers (unavailable in Squliq, as well as for other Seediq speakers: see note 25) to head-move the K head to T, realizing a genitive clitic pronoun, and keeping the agent KP's K head intact.

- (42) **Genitive clitic-doubling for some Tgdaya speakers:** [Seediq; Chang 1997: 77, 82]

Wada =**na** puq-un **na** Pawan ka ido.
 AUX =GEN.3sg eat-PV GEN Pawan NOM rice
 'Pawan ate the rice.'

Seediq also allows for optional nominative clitic-doubling as in (43), analyzed as head-movement of D to T without Removal of the original D head. This is attested in both Chang's (1997) and Aldridge's (2004) work on Tgdaya Seediq.

- (43) **Nominative clitic-doubling in Tgdaya:** [Seediq; Aldridge 2004: 214]

M-usa =**ku** mu-huma kyuuri=**na** **ka** yaku.
 AV-go =NOM.1sg AV-plant cucumber=GEN.3sg NOM 1sg
 'I went to plant his cucumbers.'

Broader cross-linguistic variation across Philippine-type languages also reinforces the idea that there is variation (by language or by probe) in whether pronominal cliticization necessarily Removes the goal noun phrase's outermost head or not. There are cases of clitic-doubling which do not affect the case marking of their associates (e.g. in Kapampangan or with Puyuma genitive agents; see Erlewine & Levin 2021 and citations there) and cases where optional clitic-doubling results in case-less noun phrase associates (e.g. in Pangasinan; see Erlewine & J. Lim 2023).

²⁴ The ungrammaticality of the variant of (41) without the genitive marker also serves to show that a KP with its K layer Removed cannot stay in-situ in the vP phase. It must have a D layer and move into the higher phase, hosted by Spec,TopP.

²⁵ However, Aldridge (2004, 2010) explicitly reports that examples of the form in (42) are *not* grammatical for her Tgdaya speakers. See Aldridge 2010: 173 ex. 11b, as well as discussion in Aldridge 2004: 215.

Nominative non-subject themes Next, I discuss the possibility of non-subject themes. My own primary Squliq speakers could comfortably nominative-mark non-subject themes in AV clauses, again as long as the subject itself is not a postverbal noun phrase (cf. (7a)). Consider the agent *wh*-question and subject clitic structures with nominative-marked non-subject themes in (44) below. Unlike with nominative non-subject agents, there is no additional pronoun doubling these nominative non-subject themes.

(44) **Nominative non-subject themes:** [Squliq]

- a. Ima (qu') [wal m-anig ____ **qu'** sehuy qasa]?
 who NOM AUX AV-eat NOM taro DIST
 'Who ate that taro?'
- b. Cyux =sami m-ita **qu'** Tali.
 AUX =NOM.1plE AV-see NOM Tali
 'We (exclusive) see Tali.'

The same possibility is attested in Tgdaya Seediq, as in (45a). Just as in Squliq, the non-subject theme cannot be nominative-marked if the subject itself is a postverbal full noun phrase.²⁶

(45) **Nominative non-subject themes in Tgdaya:** [Seediq; Holmer 1996: 67–68, 129]

- a. Q<m><n>ita =ku **ka** boyak.
 <AV><PFV>see =NOM.1SG NOM boar
 'I saw the boar (but I didn't see the hunters).'
- b. *Q<m><n>ita **ka** boyak **ka** Pawan.
 <AV><PFV>see NOM boar NOM Pawan
 Intended: 'Pawan saw a boar.' / 'The boar saw Pawan.'

I tentatively propose that these structures reflect the possibility of base-generating a DP in Spec,TopP to bind an argument position below, just when there is no nominal that moves to Spec,TopP. This approach is compatible with the proposal for the verbal phase presented above (with cross-linguistic support from the attested inventory of clitic pronouns; see Erlewine & Levin 2021), whereby a non-subject theme may never move out. It also accounts for the fact that non-subject themes cannot cooccur with a postverbal

²⁶ Holmer describes (45) with the intended interpretation 'Pawan saw a boar,' with "NOM *theme* NOM *subj*" word order, but as the string is generally reported to be ungrammatical, it must also be ungrammatical as 'The/A boar saw Pawan' with "NOM *subj* NOM *theme*" word order. Aldridge (2004) corroborates the ungrammaticality of the nominative non-subject theme cooccurring with a subject in "NOM *subj* NOM *theme*" word order in Tgdaya; see p. 45 ex. 94.

subject in Seediq, even though Seediq allows for non-subject agents together with subjects as in (38–39) above.²⁷

This analysis predicts that nominative non-subject themes should also be associated with topic status and be in a structurally high position, like nominative subjects and nominative non-subject agents, as seen above. In line with the first prediction, I observed that my Squliq speakers strongly preferred nominative-marked non-subject themes to have postnominal demonstratives, as in (46) below.²⁸ In line with the second prediction, the interrogative marker *ga'* cannot precede non-subject themes unless they are nominative-marked; see (47) below.

(46) **Nominative-marking strongly prefers demonstrative:** [Squliq]

Nyux =saku m-aniq **qu'** yutak ^{??}(qani).
 AUX.PROG =NOM.1sg AV-eat NOM orange PROX
 'I'm eating {this orange / *oranges}.'

(47) **Interrogative *ga'* shows nominative non-subject theme is high:** [Squliq]

- a. Nyux =su m-aniq {***ga'**} yutak {**ga'**}?
 AUX =NOM.2sg AV-eat orange Q
 'Are you eating oranges?'
- b. Nyux =su m-aniq {**ga'**} **qu'** yutak qani {**ga'**}?
 AUX =NOM.2sg AV-eat Q NOM orange PROX
 'Are you eating this orange?'

Finally, echoing the discussion of non-subject agent $\bar{A}$ -extraction in (37) above, I note that the availability of nominative-marking on non-subject themes does not feed $\bar{A}$ -extraction. See example (48), which reflects an attempt at $\bar{A}$ -extracting the non-subject theme from an example parallel to (44b) above. The ungrammaticality of this configuration reflects an inability to base-generate a null operator (an NP with predication semantics, as noted above) in Spec,TopP.

²⁷ My proposal here makes the prediction that nominative non-subject agents may exhibit connectivity or reconstruction effects that nominative non-subject themes do not. Unfortunately I do not have data that speaks to this prediction, and leave this prediction to be tested in future work.

²⁸ The data in my Squliq field notes are compatible with non-subject agents also reflecting this constraint: that is, nominative-marked non-subject agents overwhelmingly have postnominal demonstratives, or else are proper names. Unfortunately my notes do not include a clear minimal pair akin to what I show with a non-subject theme in (46). See also the definite enclitic on the non-subject agent in Aldridge's Tgdaya Seediq example (38b) above.

(48) **No $\bar{A}$ -extraction of non-subject theme:**

[Squliq]

*Nanu (qu') [cyux =su m-aniq ____]?

what NOM AUX =NOM.2sg AV-eat

Intended: 'What are you eating?'

Nominative non-subject time adjuncts The final extension that I discuss is the availability of nominative-marked time adjuncts. Tsukida (2005: 299–300, 2009: 320ff) and Oiwa-Bungard (2017: 20, 58–59) document this possibility in Truku Seediq, as long as the subject is not itself a postverbal phrase. See the examples in (49), including the ungrammatical example in (49c) provided by Tsukida. Like the case of nominative non-subject themes which also cannot cooccur with a postverbal subject in Seediq, I propose that these time adjunct nominals can be base-generated with a D layer in Spec,TopP, just when Spec,TopP is otherwise unoccupied.

(49) **Nominative time adjuncts in Truku:**

[Seediq; (a): Oiwa-Bungard 2017: 20; (b,c): Tsukida 2005: 299–300]

a. M-iing =ku Kuras **ka** sayang.

AV-search =NOM.1sg Kuras(OBL) NOM now

'I am looking for Kuras right now.'

b. Masaw 'u, m-bahu lukus **(ka)** ke'man sayang.

Masaw TOP AV.FUT-wash clothes(OBL) (NOM) night now

'As for Masaw, he will wash clothes tonight.'

c. *M-bahu lukus {**ka** ke'man sayang} **ka** Masaw {**ka** ke'man sayang}.

AV.FUT-wash clothes(OBL) NOM night now NOM Masaw

Tsukida furthermore notes that, like subjects (17) and nominative non-subject agents (36), a nominative-marked time expression cannot be a *wh*-word. See (50), where the subject of 'arrive' is pro-dropped in both cases. This behavior too accords with my analysis where exceptional nominative-marking is made possible by the Spec,TopP position, which is incompatible with interrogative expressions.

(50) **Nominative-marked time cannot be interrogative:**

[Seediq; Tsukida 2009: 321]

a. Mpe-dehuq karingku **ka** kusun.

AV.FUT-arrive Hualien(OBL) NOM tomorrow

'[He/she] will arrive at Hualien tomorrow.'

- b. *Mpe-dehuq karingku **ka** kenuwan?
 AV.FUT-arrive Hualien(OBL) NOM when
 Intended: ‘When will [he/she] arrive at Hualien?’

5 Conclusion

The interrelated behaviors of case and voice morphology and their relationship to $\bar{A}$ -processes in so-called Philippine-type Austronesian languages have received substantial attention in both typological and theoretical literature. Much of this work has aimed at understanding the notion of “subjecthood” (or, perhaps more neutrally, “pivotality”) and its associated behaviors, within the grammatical systems of these languages as well as in relation to historically better-studied systems of case, voice, and movement. As is common in Philippine-type languages (see e.g. Erlewine, Levin & Van Urk 2017: 376), each clause has one argument (here, the “subject”) with distinct argument coding (traditionally described as “nominative”) commonly associated with topicality, there are multiple “voices,” including options for taking certain oblique arguments as the subject, and $\bar{A}$ -extraction is limited to the subject argument. Previous accounts have debated whether the choice of subject reflects an A- or $\bar{A}$ -process, and relatedly whether “nominative” coding reflects a different case value or else an $\bar{A}$ -annotation such as a topic-marking.

Against this backdrop, this paper offers a new perspective on the nature of subjecthood and nominative marking, and their relationship to topicality. I propose a novel approach to the Philippine-type voice alternation, in the case/*wh*-agreement tradition (see e.g. Chung 1982, 1994, 1998, Pearson 2001, 2005, Rackowski 2002, Rackowski & Richards 2005, V. Chen 2017, 2025), whereby promotion to subject involves *removal* of the subject’s K head. What has been described as nominative-marking then reflects a DP without a K head, which can be licensed within the CP phase by movement to a topic position. On this account, the frequent correlations between subjecthood, topicality, and nominative-marking is indirect, allowing for certain limited mismatches. I showed that the proposal allows us to naturally account for a range of mismatches and the attested microvariation therein.

The initial motivation for this approach comes from clear morphosyntactic contrasts in the case-marking inventory of Atayalic languages. Nominative-marked nominals can be properly contained within non-nominative case-marked nominals, reflecting a structural reduction associated with nominative and hence with subjecthood. The idea that nominative marking reflects *less* morphosyntactic marking or structure as compared to other cases has been suggested previously by Reid (1978, 1979) (see also Reid & Liao 2004: 465–467) within the earlier comparative literature on Philippine-type languages. These morphological parallels suggest that the novel proposal for voice alternations here may be productively

extended to account for the behaviors of other so-called Philippine-type languages. I will leave this exploration for future work.

By way of conclusion, I note one additional consequence of my novel proposal for the voice alternation in Atayalic. Within the typology of movement types, Van Urk (2015) has proposed that the result of joint probing for an A-feature and an $\bar{A}$ -feature leads to so-called “composite A/ $\bar{A}$ -movement,” which exhibits a mix of A- and $\bar{A}$ -movement properties. (See Postal 1971 and Chomsky 1981 on the classic distinction, as well as Lohninger 2024 for a recent overview which addresses the behavior of “composite” movements.) Recall from section 3.2 that probes on the head v identify a single goal (via Multitasking; see (22)) to satisfy [uCase], a K-Removal feature ($[-K^0-]$; see note 14), as well as an $\bar{A}$ -edge feature. As a result, we may expect the movement of Atayalic subjects (to the phase edge and then to TopP, potentially crossing other arguments) to exhibit a mix of A- and $\bar{A}$ -movement properties as well. I observe that this is a positive result.

V. Chen (2017, 2025) claims that subject promotion in Seediq (as well as various other Philippine-type voice system languages) exhibits $\bar{A}$ -properties, for instance demonstrating that subjects can reconstruct for variable binding; see (51). However, promotion to subject also has the possibility of *feeding* variable binding in Seediq (see (52)) as well as obviating Condition C (that is, does not obligatorily reconstruct for Condition C) in Squliq (see (53)).²⁹

(51) **Subject can reconstruct for variable binding:** [Seediq; V. Chen 2025: 184]

Gulu-un liyun [na kn-kingal bubu]_i [ka laqi=daha].
 love-PV very GEN RED-one mother NOM child=GEN.3pl
 ‘[Every mother]_i loves [her_i child].’

(52) **Subject promotion feeds variable binding (without WCO):** [Seediq; Wu 2025: 8]

- a. *Wada m-emux [kn-kingal laqi]_i [ka bubu=daha_i].
 AUX AV-hug RED-one child(OBL) NOM mother=GEN.3pl
 ‘[Their_i mother] hugged [every child]_i.’
- b. Wada mex-un [na bubu=daha_i] [ka kn-kingal laqi]_i.
 AUX hug-PV GEN mother=GEN.3pl NOM RED-one child(OBL)
 ‘[Their_i mother] hugged [every child]_i.’

²⁹ The latter two properties accord with the behavior of movement to the V2 prefield in Dinka (Nilotic), which Van Urk (2015) identifies as a canonical case of “composite A/ $\bar{A}$ -movement.” See exx. 42, 43a on page 114 for the obviation of Condition C violations and exx. 34b, 35b on page 110 for movement feeding variable binding without incurring a Weak Crossover violation, parallel to the examples in (52–53). Van Urk does not discuss configurations parallel to (51).

V. Chen (2017) presents structurally parallel evidence to (52b) from Tgdaya Seediq on page 188, exx. 20a,b and page 123 ex. 56c. She also presents another example that is structurally similar but where subject promotion apparently does *not* feed variable binding (p. 186 ex. 13c). It is unclear why these examples do not pattern together.

(53) **Subject promotion obviates Condition C:**

[Squiliq; T. Chen 2014: 9]

- a. M-asuq m-aniq [sehuy na Yumin_j] qu hiya_{i/*j}.
AV-finish AV-eat taro(OBL) GEN Yumin NOM 3sg
'He/she_{i/*j} finished eating [Yumin_j's taros].'
- b. Suq-un =nya_{i/j} m-aniq [qu sehuy na Yumin_j].
finish-PV =GEN.3sg AV-eat NOM taro(OBL) GEN Yumin
'He/she_{i/j} finished eating [Yumin_j's taros].'

Further work is necessary in order to better document and understand the movement properties associated with subject promotion in Atayalic languages, as well as the broader range of Philippine-type languages, as well as potential variation therein. However, I conclude here by noting that the novel derivational syntax of voice that I propose here — combined with work on the distribution of A- vs $\bar{A}$ - properties as in Van Urk 2015 — appears to make accurate predictions regarding additional interpretational and binding-related properties associated with subjecthood in Atayalic languages that have gone unexplained in previous accounts.

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